between the creation of superhero comics and the oppression and discrimination of Jewish people.

Most of these writers were second-generation immigrants, struggling between identities. They were Jewish, and also American; they had a role in shaping the culture, but were also isolated from it in some way. Whether they were alien 'immigrants' like Superman or American-born soldiers such as Rogers, the throng of red, white and blue heroes was a way for Jewish creators to explore the national identity of their new home and mirror America back to itself in a way that only outsiders could. That's not to say it was purposeful: Kirby often denied the existence of any political messages in his work. Yet while he and his peers were inking the latest adventures, updates about the atrocities in Europe would filter through to them from friends and relatives still living across the Atlantic.

"They knew the Nazis were the bad guys well before the rest of America made up its mind," says Dittner. It's not surprising that creators incorporated their frustration and horror into the fantastic adventures they wrote. It was a time when the real world needed heroes. Pen and ink superheroes provided hope and wish fulfilment, showing caped crusaders fighting fascism with only a powerful uppercut and a pun-derful quip.

> **THE FALCON HAS TO TEACH CAPTAIN AMERICA TO SEE THE RACISM AT THE HEART OF AMERICAN CULTURE**
> JASON DITTMER

Of course, super-patriots were nothing without their supervillains. While comic-book heroes now duke it out with ferocious space creatures and unstable scientists, Captain American and his fellow patriots took on real threats, undisguised by symbolism or metaphors. Nazis and later Japanese soldiers were seen as real-life supervillains, which gave artists and writers the perfect foil for their fictional creations. With a nation's hatred of fascism supporting them, writers were free to litter their pages with grossly caricatured German and Japanese villains, typified as cowardly, pathetic sub-humans, yet still capable of giving America a bloody nose until the heroes came along. Most terrifying of all was Cap's main foe, the Red Skull, a hideous crimson Nazi emblazoned with a swastika. As Dittmer notes, "One of the effects of these comics is that they import the moral clarity of the superhero universe into our own perceptions of 'real' history."

In some ways, these comic-books also served as low-level propaganda, presenting characters who were so besotted with their country that they'd risk their lives, and many books of the time included pleas for readers to support the war effort at home. "You too are a superhero," the comics seemed to say.

Comics were frequently shipped across to American troops as well, and were thought to foster feelings of national pride and bolster the morale of troops. However by the time 1945 came around, the war had been won, and slowly the effects of the war receded. *Captain America*'s first run struggled on until 1949, when it ceased production. There were a few aborted attempts to continue the glory days when the nation was united against fascism, but ultimately the patriotic fervour of World War II faded. As the Cold War progressed, some comics tried to incorporate anti-communist storylines in the same way



With the war's end in 1945, characters like Captain America would struggle to find their place.

O CAPTAIN! MY CAPTAIN!

Who else took the Captain's name?

ISAIAH BRADLEY



In a storyline which echoed the real-life Tuskegee syphilis trials, African-American Isaiah and his peers were injected with the super-serum without their consent. All the subjects died apart from Isaiah, who went on to be known as 'the black Captain America'

WILLIAM NASLAND



As a way to retcon Captain America's exploits during the Fifties, it was revealed that Truman had actually appointed Nasland, aka second-stringer The Spirit Of '76, as Cap's replacement after the original had disappeared in combat.

WILLIAM BURNSIDE



Beware the dangers of incomplete super-serum. Burnside took a bad batch, changed his name to Steve Rogers and embarked on a crazed war against communism in the Fifties. Like so many other heroes, it all ended in forced suspended animation for him.

JAMES 'BUCKY' BARNES



Following Rogers' death in 2007, Bucky took on the role of Captain America, according to his mentor's wishes, although he operated by his own rules. Bucky faked his death after a period of controversy, and Rogers returned to take up the shield.